The world in brief

Catch up quickly on the global stories that matter

Israeli officials travelled to Egypt for another round of talks over a **ceasefire deal** in Gaza. According to Reuters, Hamas representatives would not be present in Cairo as they await an Israeli offer. The negotiations are thought to revolve around a six-week pause in Israel's operation in Gaza in return for the freedom of the remaining hostages taken by Hamas during the October 7th attack. Meanwhile, the office of Israel's prime minister, Binyamin Netayanhu, said that he would be admitted to hospital for a hernia operation.

Opposition candidates in **Turkey** looked to have achieved notable wins in local elections. An initial count in Istanbul showed the incumbent opposition mayor, Ekrem Imamoglu, heading for a second term. That would be a blow for Recep Tayyip Erdogan, whose Justice and Development (AK) party hoped to retake the city. Another opposition figure, Mansur Yavas, declared victory over AK in Ankara, the capital.

Chinese manufacturing activity grew in March, the first such rise in six months. The manufacturing purchasing managers' index was 50.8 this month, compared with 49.1 in February (anything over 50 denotes expansion). An increase in export orders explains the rise. Despite the positive news, China's statistics agency warned that firms still face "insufficient market demand".

Thousands of opposition supporters protested in **Delhi** against the arrest of **Arvind Kejriwal**, the Indian capital city's chief minister. Mr Kejriwal was arrested on March 21st on corruption charges, which his supporters claim are politically motivated. The ruling Bharatiya Janata Party denies interfering in the case. India's

general election begins on April 19th. Narendra Modi, the prime minister, is expected to win.

Ukraine said that Russia launched 16 missiles and 11 drones in an overnight attack. The governor of the Lviv region in western Ukraine said that one man died. Russia has increased air strikes recently as it seeks to destroy Ukraine's energy infrastructure. The country's biggest energy firm, DTEK, said that five out of its six plants have been damaged or destroyed, causing an 80% reduction in capacity.

A **car bomb** killed at least seven people in **northern Syria**. The blast in Azaz, a town close to the border with Turkey, happened near a busy market. The Syrian Interim Government, an opposition group which opposes the rule of Bashar al-Assad, the country's president, is based in the town. No group has yet claimed responsibility for the attack.

AT&T said that personal information of 73m of its current and former customers had been posted on the dark web. The telecoms firm said that social-security numbers were among the data that were leaked. It said it did not yet know the source of the breach and that the information appeared to be from 2019 or before.

Word of the week: *Le dry January*, a phrase that has recently entered France's national lexicon. Read the full story.

Photo: EPA

Turkey’s not-so-local election in Istanbul

Most of the mayoral and municipal contests being held in Turkey’s 81 provinces on Sunday are about things like public transport and sanitation. But in some, especially Istanbul, the future of the country’s politics is at stake.

Ekrem Imamoglu won a shock victory five years ago and became Istanbul’s mayor. He held a narrow lead in the pre-voting opinion polls. Another win and he’d be a shoo-in as the opposition’s candidate in presidential elections in 2028. But Recep Tayyip Erdogan, Turkey’s president, and his Justice and Development party are determined to recapture Turkey’s largest city, along with its $16bn budget and vast patronage networks. If Justice and Development’s mayoral candidate, Murat Kurum, wins it might also embolden Turkey’s autocratic leader, who has ruled the country for over two decades, to pursue his latest pet project. Mr Erdogan wants a new constitution, presumably to give himself another term. Whoever said all politics is local was clearly not Turkish.

Photo: Getty Images

Ethiopia’s tiger no longer roars

Not long ago Ethiopia’s tiger economy enjoyed world-beating growth rates and significant reductions in poverty. No longer. In December, it became the latest African country to default on a loan repayment—an aftershock of a devastating war in the Tigray region which ended in late 2022. With debt accumulating and foreign exchange reserves depleting, Ethiopian officials are racing to secure around $3.5bn from the IMF before a deadline set by some of the country’s creditors on March 31st.

If it lapses without cash from the fund, a deal to suspend debt payments until 2025 will be in jeopardy. So too might negotiations with commercial bondholders to reschedule a $1bn loan due in December. Officials hope the IMF will give them the space to continue much-needed economic reforms, and unlock funding from the World Bank and other concessional lenders. The stakes are high: with much of the country still mired in conflict, large parts are on the brink of famine.

Photo: Getty Images

London’s Tavistock paediatric gender clinic closes

The closure of one of Britain’s most controversial clinics has been a drawn-out affair. The Gender Identity Development Service at the Tavistock foundation trust was once the world’s largest children’s gender clinic, offering puberty blockers and cross-sex hormones. In 2020, amid criticism that its procedures were not evidence-based, inspectors found the service “inadequate”. In 2022 an independent National Health Service review called for a “fundamentally different” approach, prioritising psychological treatment over medical intervention. The clinic will close on March 31st.

Two regional services will replace it, with more planned—but their capacity will probably be insufficient to reduce the waiting list of 6,000. Controversy will continue. On March 12th the NHS said it would ban puberty blockers for children under 18. But it is expanding access to cross-sex hormones for adults and announced on March 21st, to widespread surprise, that children will be able to take them, too, from “around their 16th birthday”, even without having first taken puberty blockers.

Photo: Lea Mok/HKFP

A beloved bookshop closes in Hong Kong

A slogan runs above the entrance of Mount Zero, an independent bookshop: “ideas are bulletproof”. Maybe, but in Hong Kong they are certainly targets. Since the government in Beijing enacted a national-security law in 2020, many independent bookshops associated with pro-democracy movements have closed. Mount Zero, which shuts this week, is the latest.

Texts that might rile the government, for instance on pro-democracy protests in 2019, have disappeared from shelves since the NSL was introduced. (Hong Kong passed its own version of the law on March 19th.) In 2022 five speech therapists were jailed under a colonial-era sedition law for publishing a children’s book about wolves and sheep.

Sources claim the authorities sometimes heap legal challenges on shops to close them down. Mount Zero, which has sometimes been associated with the pro-democracy movement, received such treatment. It was told its front step was illegally occupying government land in September. Being bulletproof doesn’t protect you from everything.

Photo: Getty Images

Weekend profile: Arvind Kejriwal, Delhi's detained anti-corruption crusader

Arvind Kejriwal claims to be the victim of a stitch-up. On March 21st Delhi's chief minister and the leader of India's opposition Aam Aadmi Party, which runs the capital and the northern state of Punjab, was arrested for allegedly failing to co-operate with an investigation into kickbacks the AAP supposedly received for alcohol licences.

Mr. Kejriwal protests, arguably with good cause, that Narendra Modi, the prime minister, and his ruling Bharatiya Janata Party are going after him to distract from their own corrupt practice of systematically investigating political opponents. (The BJP denied doing this.) On Saturday supporters of the INDIA Alliance, a 27-party bloc opposed to the BJP, will take to Delhi's streets to demand Mr Kejriwal's release. They want to make sure that one of their most popular leaders is allowed to campaign in India's general election, which starts on April 19th.

It would be grimly ironic if Mr Kejriwal lost his role in public life because of graft allegations. An engineer-turned-civil servant from

northern India, the 55-year-old rose to prominence as a rabble-rousing campaigner leading a popular movement against endemic corruption during the Congress-led government that preceded Mr Modi. He founded the AAP on this image. The party's symbol is a broom—symbolising its commitment to sweeping away corruption.

Mr Kejriwal built a reputation for good governance in his ten years-plus as chief minister of Delhi, despite constant attempts by the central government to undermine his administration. Aided by his deputy, Manish Sisodia, who has been in jail since last February in connection with the same investigation that has ensnared his boss, Mr Kejriwal turned the capital's failing education system around. It is now regarded as one of the country's best. He also improved health care, particularly for Delhi's poorest.

His anti-graft credentials have made Mr Kejriwal a thorn in the side of Mr Modi, who is loth to see an opponent project an aura of incorruptibility. The BJP has also stepped up its hounding of other parts of the opposition, as the election draws closer. Mr Modi has had success painting politicians from the long-established Congress Party—with which Mr Kejriwal's party has allied—as corrupt, elitist and out of touch. Mr Kejriwal, a conservative, technocratic upstart, is harder to tar with the same brush.

The winners of this week’s quiz

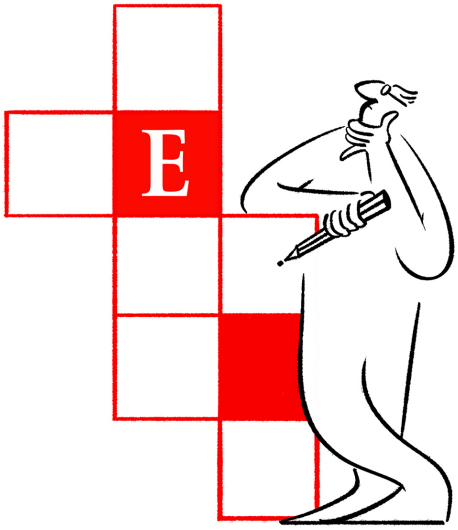
Thank you to everyone who took part in this week’s quiz. The winners, chosen at random, were:

Rik Mulder, Hilversum, The Netherlands
Tetsuyuki Maruyama, Ito, Japan
Emil Skodon, Washington DC, America

They all gave the correct answers of Joseph Smith, sunset clause, The Phantom Menace, the Orient Express, and cats. The theme is Andrew Lloyd Webber musicals: Joseph and the Amazing Technicolour Dreamcoat, Sunset Boulevard, The Phantom of the Opera, Starlight Express and Cats.

The questions were:

Monday: Who was the founder of Mormonism? He published the Book of Mormon in 1830
Tuesday: What is the usual term for a provision in a bill that provides for a law to expire after a certain date?
Wednesday: What was the name of the first prequel in the Star Wars movie series, released in 1999?
Thursday: What was the name of the luxury train service that ran from Paris to Istanbul?
Friday: Abyssinian, Burmese and Persian are all types of which creature?



Weekly crossword

Our crossword has two sets of clues, one for seasoned cruciverbalists and the other for less experienced solvers. Both give the same answers, all of which feature in articles in this week's edition of *The Economist*:

Cryptic clues

1 *down* Awful cataract in unforgiving location (10)

1 *across* Saying a bit of Dickens takes a long time (5)

2 *across* Hazard in bazaar is known (4)

3 *across* Almost completely inadequate record (5)

Factual clues

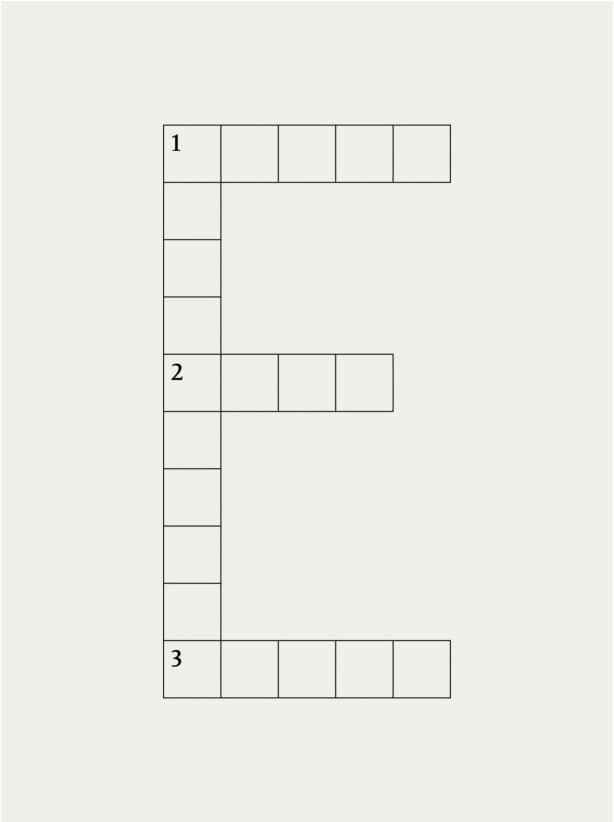
1 *down* Earth's largest refrigerator (10)

1 *across* What "all models are wrong" might be for statisticians (5)

2 *across* What Europe is trying to minimise from China (4)

3 *across* Beyoncé's "Cowboy Carter", for example (5)

Email all four answers, along with your home city and country, by 9am GMT on Monday to . We will pick randomly from those with the right answers and crown three winners in next week's edition.



Find things beautiful as much as you can, most people find too little beautiful.

Vincent van Gogh